The Thing about Turbulence

By Elliott Hester

INTRODUCTION

Many people fear flying. After all, once you get on an airplane, you are committed to it for the duration of your journey; there's no pulling over and stopping if you get uncomfortable. And while airplane crashes are much less common than car accidents, the media attention they receive makes them seem like a real threat. It's little wonder, then, that airplane turbulence makes many travelers uneasy. It can happen without warning, causing a plane to shudder and dip erratically. Fear is a natural reaction – unless you are a flight attendant. Then it's just a minor inconvenience . . . right? Well, here's "The Thing About Turbulence" by Elliott Hester

Imagine you are floating

Released from the grip of gravity, you soar through recirculated airplane cabin air, high above those who were wise enough to heed the captain's P.A. announcement. You are still clutching a plastic cup in one hand, but the beverage is now dripping from your seatmate's face. The other hand has released the periodical you'd been reading, bringing a whole new

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meaning to the term "in-flight" magazine. You see these images, and more, in the slow-motion, frame-by-frame vision of one who has been forcibly ejected from his seat.

From this new and unusual vantage point, you look around and catch glimpses of insanity: a walking cane, minus its owner, hurtling through the cabin: a laptop crashing against a bulkhead: an explosion of peanuts; a sea of twisting heads; overhead bins opening like a chorus line of jaws – ejecting hats, coats and a whole slew of carry-on bags. No longer do you have to imagine how it would feel to fly. You *are* flying. You are a virtual Peter Pan – an airborne tourist, caught in the seismic upheaval of midair turbulence

This is what can happen when you fail to buckle your seat belt.

And don't forget that the seat belt sign blinked on several minutes earlier. The flight attendants had roamed down the aisle, reminding everyone to buckle up, and the captain had warned of bumpy skies ahead. He told you to stay in your seat, to strap in tight, to be

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ready for a good jolt or two. However, as with most airplane announcements (except for those warning about delays or flight diversions), you regarded the captain's remarks as gibberish. Besides, you don't like wearing your seat belt. It's too restrictive. You were annoyed when a flight attendant interrupted your conversation to tell you to buckle up. In fact, you rolled your eyes and frowned at her.

So, just to piss her off, you think about getting up to go to the bathroom – even though the plane is trembling as if hit by an earthquake. You'll just walk right on over to the lavatory, stumbling if you have to, ignoring the attendant who will probably be strapped in her jump seat, pleading for you to sit down. You decide to do this, but you never get the chance. While you're still in your seat – with your unfastened seat belt dangling from the cushion – the airplane suddenly drops a couple hundred feet.

Now look at you. Folded like a pretzel between rows 27 and 28, five rows from where you once sat.

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In-flight turbulence is nothing to kid about. Our Emergency Procedures and Training report claims that each year, an average of fifty-eight passengers are injured in the U.S. while not wearing their seat belts during turbulence. This is the leading cause of injury to passengers and crew in nonfatal accidents.

In the ten-month period between October 1999 and August 2000, some seventy-two passengers were injured in four separate incidents involving Chinese, Japanese, U.S. and British airlines. Perhaps the most serious incident occurred when a China Southern Airlines flight – en route from Kunming in southwestern Ching to Hong Kong – plunged two thousand feet, injuring forty-five passengers in the process. Though several of the injured were treated at a hospital and discharged, twenty-one had longer hospital stays. Seven remained in serious condition.

Chances are, none of the injured was wearing a seat belt.

This brings to mind a video that is part of the New York Department of Motor Vehicle license

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application process. After finishing the driver's test, applicants are required to attend a few hours of class, which includes a video showing in glaring detail a series of gruesome accident scenes. A state trooper then appears on-screen to address the group. When the other driver wanna-bes and I watched the video, we began to have second thoughts about driving the streets of New York. In a strong, authoritative, "I've seen it all so you better listen" voice, Trooper Johnson left us with one parting thought about driver safety. "In all my years on the force," he said. "I've never had to pull a dead person from behind a buckled seat belt."

Trooper Johnson had a good point.

Since that day, I have never failed to wear a seat belt while riding in a car. And because the trooper's advice can be easily applied to airplane passengers faced with in-flight turbulence, I always wear my seat belt when traveling as a passenger. While on duty, however, I'm forced to throw caution to the wind. The nature of the job demands that flight attendants check for compliance when the seat belt sign winks on during

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turbulence. It's no surprise, then, that we're usually the first to get injured.

During one particular flight to the Caribbean, I stood before the toilet in an airplane lavatory, eyes closed, pants gathered around my ankles answering the primal call of nature. When you stop and think about it, relieving oneself is one of life's most tranquil experiences: a moment of reflection, an escape from the rigors of the work day, a blessed accomplishment that ends with a sigh of relief. But before my bladder could be purged, I found myself mashed against the ceiling with my feet dangling precariously above the toilet.

Over the years, colleagues have told me they've been slammed against the cabin ceiling or thrown into the laps of startled passengers. I've heard about the busted backs, fractured limbs and bloodied faces that resulted when passengers didn't buckle up, even after the seat belt sign flashed on, even after the crew had completed a mandatory safety check and P.A. announcements warned of dangerous bumps ahead.

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One fellow flight attendant was slammed against the ceiling so violently that his uniform shirt ended up covered with blood. Luckily, he sustained no permanent injuries. But when the plane landed, and the more severely injured passengers were removed, an airline supervisor walked up and asked him to change his shirt.

Can't have bloodied flight attendants limping through the airport terminal, now can we?

Like most flight attendants, I've been forced to scramble to my jump seat during moments of rough turbulence. When chaos strikes, and the plane starts bucking like a mechanical bull gone berserk, we slam and lock galley doors, strap into our jump seats, then look at each other with disbelieving eyes. If ever I was to be launched toward the ceiling, I always imagined it would happen out in the aisle or in the galley, surrounded by shrieking humanity. I never thought that turbulence would strike when I was alone, in the lavatory, with my underwear at half mast.

Without warning, I seemed to float toward the ceiling. I was an astronaut in the middle of a

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weightlessness experiment. A mortal sent airborne against his will. In a split second I had gone from the sublime to the ridiculous. With my back pressed high against the lavatory wall, neck bent against the ceiling at an angle that only a contortionist could appreciate, I was at the mercy of God and aircraft dynamics.

That's when I peed all over the toilet and the walls. I even let loose on my own shoes. This embarrassing act was not the result of fear. There wasn't enough time to be scared. It happened because turbulence hit before I could finish my business.

The experience brought back childhood memories of an amusement park ride. Twenty or thirty people entered a large round room devoid of straps or any safety apparatus. The door shut behind us. A disembodied voice then instructed us to lean back against the wall. The room spun slowly at first, then picked up speed, with the centrifugal force pinning us against the spinning wall. Then the floor dropped, and we spun around and around, stuck to the wall like wet clothes in the final wash cycle.

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Everybody loved it. I did too.

But I did not love my experience in the airplane lavatory.

In the next split second, I watched in horror as a couple of gallons of d-germ cam splashing up and out of the toilet. (D-germ is the pungent blue chemical that swishes around the toilet bowl after every flush. It's designed to break down wasted and mask unpleasant odors by creating an unpleasant odor of its own.) It was a true comic moment. A Monty Python sketch come to life. My trousers became soaked with d-germ. My only consolation was that there were no chunks.

The airplane suddenly regained its composure. Gravity reestablished its grip. Wobbly as an Olympic gymnast who'd been drinking martinis the night before a crucial vault, my feet hit the floor and I came sprawling through the open lavatory door.

Nobody on the plan was hurt. Everyone, including my fellow crew members, had been wearing seat belts. Startled and only slightly bruised, I strapped myself into the jump seat, smelling of urine and d-germ.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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